killed in those gurudwaras. Either there was not a large number of militants in the first place or they had already escaped. [11]

On 4 June, announcements were made over loudspeakers asking pilgrims inside the Golden Temple to leave the premises and the extremists to surrender with their weapons. But in the din and confusion that prevailed in the hostel complex of the temple, these announcements were not clearly audible. Only 129 persons came out of the temple area in the first lot. 'With no militant willing to surrender, army found itself suddenly faced with a situation that it had not anticipated and for which, therefore, it had not been prepared.' [12]

Thereafter, the army began bombarding the Ramgarhia Bunga, the overhead water tank and other positions. After destroying the outer defences, the army moved tanks and APCs (armoured personnel carriers) on to the road separating the main temple complex and the Guru Ram Das Sarai, Teja Singh Samundri Hall and Guru Nanak Niwas. Longowal and SGPC chairman G.S. Tohra were still in the SGPC office area of Teja Singh Samundri Hall, but Badal had left for his village. In view of his known proximity to Bhindranwale, Tohra felt he might be able to convince him to surrender. Therefore, soon after the firing stopped on the morning of 4 June, Tohra went to the Akal Takht (obviously, with the knowledge and approval of the authorities concerned) to meet Bhindranwale.

His advice was spurned by Bhindranwale, who accused Tohra of being Indira Gandhi's agent. Tohra and the authorities concerned should have known that by then Bhindranwale had talked himself into a position from where abject surrender before the army was unthinkable. He could not have lived with that humiliation for the rest of his life. He would rather die fighting and become a part of Sikh folklore, as a martyr who gave his life to defend the Harmandir Sahib complex.

The same night (June 4), foreign and Indian journalists working for foreign media were made to leave Punjab. However, Brahma Chellaney, a young Indian reporter working for Associated Press (AP), managed to stay on as he had arrived in Amritsar that very